

Beta Launch Checklist

Print this and check items off as we go.

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Legend: ☐ = not started ☒ = in progress ☒ = done

Phase 0 — Code hardening (no accounts needed)

- ☐ **Email verification non-blocking for beta** — env toggle so testers aren't locked out before SMTP
- ☐ **Password reset** — forgot password → email link → set new password
- ☐ **Rate limiting** on public API (signup/login/post abuse protection)
- ☐ **Lock down CORS** to the real frontend domain (env allowlist)
- ☐ **Server-side input validation** pass on all write endpoints (*body-cap + core done; full sweep pending*)
- ☐ **.env.example** documenting every config value
- ☐ **Friendly 404 / error pages** + consistent API error shape
- ☐ **Data backup** strategy (even a daily file copy for now)

Phase 1 — Production data layer

- ☐ **Decision:** keep JSON file (tiny closed beta only) OR move to Postgres
- ☐ If Postgres: schema + migration from current JSON
- ☐ Seed/admin script for test accounts
- ☐ Automated backup (snapshot/dump on a schedule)

Phase 2 — Deployment (get a shareable URL)

- ☐ **Single-service architecture** — Express serves built frontend + API on one origin (no CORS)
- ☐ **Deploy config** committed: Dockerfile, render.yaml blueprint, npm start, configurable data dir
- ☐ **Production build** verified locally (serves UI + API, SPA routing, data persists to mounted dir)
- ☐ **Pick a host & deploy** (Render Blueprint recommended) — *needs your host account*
- ☐ Set production **env vars** on the host (APP_URL, attach persistent disk)
- ☐ HTTPS + custom domain (optional; host provides HTTPS by default)
- ☐ Smoke-test the full loop on the live URL

Phase 3 — Integrations (need your credentials)

- ☐ **Real SMTP** (verification, resets, notifications)
- ☐ Geocoder: keep free Nominatim for beta OR add paid key
- ☐ **Stripe** — NOT needed for free beta; defer to paid phase

Phase 4 — Observability & safety

- ☐ **Error monitoring** (e.g. Sentry) for crashes testers hit
- ☐ Structured request/error logging on the server
- ☐ Basic uptime check / health ping
- ☐ (Optional) lightweight analytics: signups, posts, bids

Phase 5 — Beta operations & legal

- ☐ **Closed-beta gating** (invite code or allowlist)
- ☐ **Feedback channel** (in-app link, form, or email)
- ☐ **Privacy Policy + Terms of Service** (required to collect emails)
- ☐ Short “Welcome to the beta” guide for testers
- ☐ Final pre-launch smoke test + go/no-go

Definition of “ready for closed beta”

All of **Phase 0**, **Phase 2**, the **SMTP** item in Phase 3, plus **Phase 5** gating + feedback + privacy/terms. Phase 1 (Postgres) and Phase 4 (monitoring) can trail slightly for a small invite-only group, but should land before opening it wider.